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CERTIFICATION COURSE

Public Speaking

Lecture 11: Cultural Awareness in Public Speaking

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What is Culture?

- ❖ “Culture is a code we learn and share, and learning and sharing require communication. Communication requires coding and symbols that must be learnt and shared.”
- (Alfred G. Smith, Preface to *Communication and Culture*)
- ❖ Symbols, rituals, values and heroes (Geert Hofstede)
- ❖ To understand a culture one needs to understand things as language and gestures, personal appearance, social relationships, religion, philosophy and values, family customs, education and communication systems.

In China, children adore Mu Lan, a woman of 6th century for her filial devotion.

“Language and Culture are frameworks through which humans experience, communicate, and understand reality”
(Lev Vygotsky, 1968).



Talking through Cultural Differences

- Public speaking across different cultures is essentially about recognizing and respecting cultural differences.
- The differences shall encompass both demographic factors such as age, gender, race, ethnicity, ability, language, economic and social status.



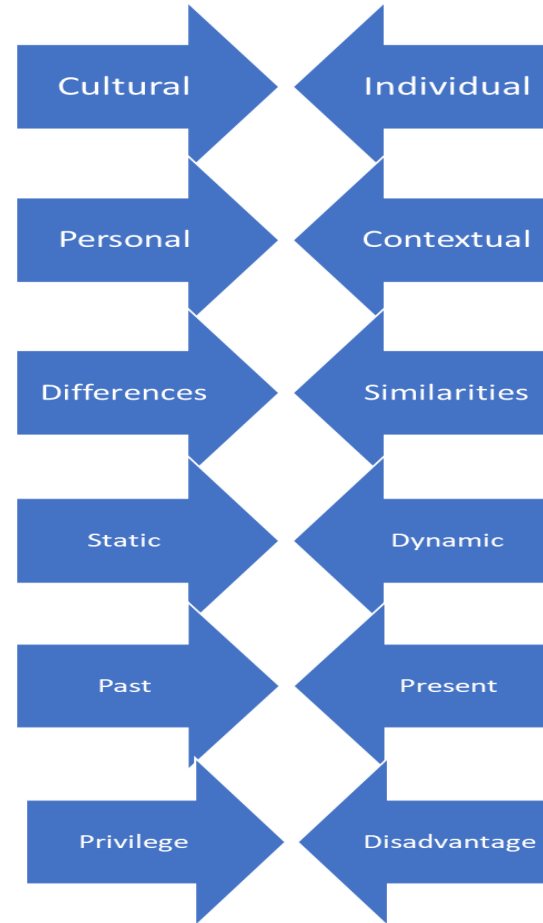
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Intercultural Communication

- Scholars like Martin and Nakayama (2010) called intercultural communication as a dialectic approach.
- Both the speaker and the listener try to participate in an interaction, irrespective of their cultural differences, and learn something new.
- It is in between this interactive experience that the sharing of minds and culture occurs.
- Public speaking provides space for a dialectic flux to happen which shall eventually lead to a better understanding of oneself, others and the world in general.



Dialectics of Intercultural Communication (Martin & Nakayama, 2010)



Cultural Intelligence

- The term “Cultural Intelligence” was coined in the year 2003 by theorists namely Christopher Early and Soon Ang.
- It is also known in other synonymous terms such as Cultural Quotient (CQ) and Cultural Competence.
- The idea of cultural intelligence to a public speaker relies upon his/her ability to communicate and convey the chosen message with intended effect to a multicultural audience.
- Audience group on the receiving end will usually display heterogeneity of cultures and languages.
- Thus, a good public speaker has to be culturally aware and competent.



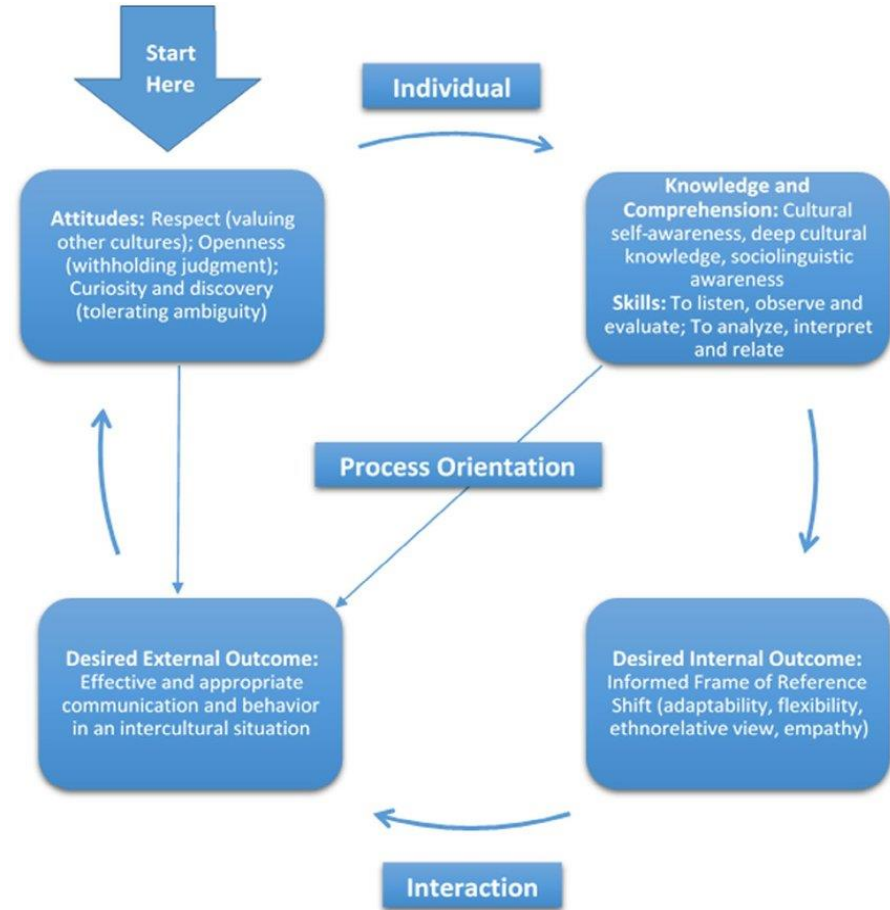
How to Achieve Cultural Competence?

- Cultural competence is not a goal to achieve but only a process to carry on and grow.
- An experienced public speaker would require pertinent practice and continuous exercise.
- Qualities like open-mindedness and respect for other cultures shall set grounds for a speaker to be culturally competent.
- Deardorff's model (2004) of intercultural competence illustrates on how acquiring cultural intelligence and awareness is a cyclical process.

Deardorff's Model of Intercultural Competence

It comprises five important elements:

1. Attitudes
2. Knowledge
3. Skills
4. Internal Outcomes
5. External Outcomes





Public Speaking and Multiculturalism

As how interpersonal communication sets platform for exchange of ideas, intercultural communication acts as a passage for cultural awareness.

A public speaker shall understand more about himself and his verbal qualities better as s/he gets acquainted with different cultures.

Cultures can be studied better through interactions than observation.

Culture and communication are intertwined (McLean 2005).

Connect the Cultural Gap

- Assess the speech response through direct and indirect feedback you receive from the other end.
- Rectify the strength of communication based upon the received feedback.
- “Cultural codes” act as the key to unlock and connect the gap between the speaker and audience.
- Public speaking rehearsals and a research outlook of the place of presentation would help at best.
- Urge to know (curiosity) and to learn (knowledge) can guide speaker to receive and process cultural feedback far efficiently.



Bridging Cultural Gap in Business

- When speaking in a national or global workspace, a public speaker must ensure to undertake **formal tone** at all costs.
- Be concise and straightforward as much possible.
- Stick to the literal meanings of the words uttered.
- Learn few foreign phrases with respect to the diversity of colleagues for interaction and greeting purposes.
- Listen actively. Reply back in a self-composed manner.



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Bridging Cultural Gap in Classroom

- The aim of public speaking in a classroom set-up is to build a fine rapport between students and teachers.
- Public speaking shall enable a sense of community in the classroom.
- It also acts as a channel for not just teachers but also for students to express themselves freely.
- With a better interaction between students and teachers, the classroom becomes a more inclusive space for diversity of individuals to thrive and grow together.



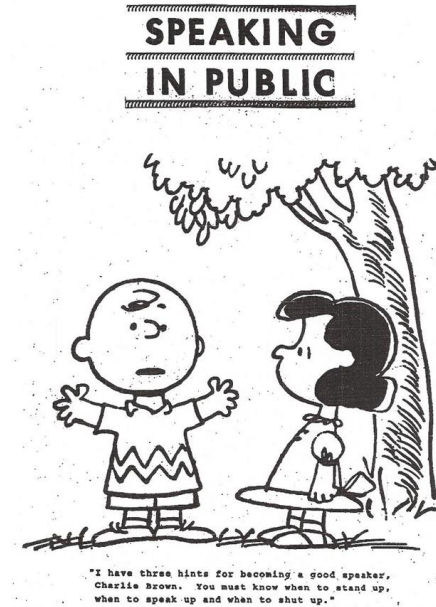
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Evaluating Audience Learning Preferences

- A speaker should afford to put themselves in the shoes of listeners before final presentation.
- With sufficient knowledge gained through audience analysis, the speaker shall figure out the learning preferences of audience.
- **Learning preference** of audience indicates the preferred medium through which audience would like to process information and understand.
- Depending on which, a speaker shall use **aural, visual or theoretical support** to connect and convey effectively.

Use of Humor in Multicultural Setup

- Humor is a double-edged sword when it comes to public speaking.
- In a pluralistic setup, a public speaker is bound to exercise more caution.
- Chances are high that the audience may not get the joke or misunderstand the applied sense of humor.
- The linguistic pluralism should be checked. Usage of British and American English should be moderated according to the type of audience.
- The content prepared as slides or graphic support should be ensured to not contain anything offensive.



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Check Cultural Bias

- Cultural bias is a two-way barrier when it comes for a speaker to address a diverse audience group.
- First, it is the cultural bias that stays with the speaker.
- The second type exists amongst the audience group, collectively or individually.
- Former kind of bias can be checked and eliminated through research and practice on the given topic.
- While the latter can be regulated by establishing a clear understanding of the cultural context of topic and audience addressed.

Cultural Caution in Public Speaking

- With all learning experience and knowledge brought forward by a cultural cluster of audience, it also raises concerns to be taken care of for a smooth communication process.
- Every public speaker must prepare themselves on the following criteria before confronting an intercultural room of audience.
 - ✓ Style and Directedness (High context cultures vs Low context cultures)
 - ✓ High Context Cultures. e.g. Japan - focus on politeness and subtlety.
 - ✓ Low Context Cultures. e.g. Germany - direct and straightforward.
 - ✓ Individualism Versus Collectivism
 - ✓ External Appearance (in terms with the place of presentation)
 - ✓ Eye contact.

How High and Low Context Cultures differ?

- ❑ High context culture (Japan, China and Arab countries)
 - ✓ Intuitive, contemplative, stress on non-verbals, meaning to physical and social setting
- ❑ Low context culture (North America, Scandinavia, France and Germany)
 - ✓ Logical, analytical and action oriented.
 - ✓ Values individualism

Some Instances of Cultural Differences

❑ Superstitions

❖ In Mexico

Saloon where people gather to drink pulque, a distillate of cactus, is considered good fortune to get worms in your cup

❖ In Japan

Maneki neko (beckoning cat)

❖ In China

Phonetic sound of 8 is most fortuitous of numbers auguring prosperity

❖ Hong Kong

A license plate with eight number is quite valuable
4 can be read as shi , a homophone for death.



Contd...

- ❖ Red is a symbol for Christian charity and for Communism and class conflict.
- ❖ Latin Americans do not stick to time.
- ❖ Mourning is symbolized by yellow in Philippines.
- ❖ It's impolite to offer gifts to a man's wife in Arab.
- ❖ Failure to make an anytime visit in India is an insult.

Overcoming Cultural Differences

- Appreciation and tolerance
- Respect other cultures the same as yours
- Prefer Commonalities to differences
- Use of unbiased language
- Empathy and adaptability

**“Culture is the widening of the mind and
of the spirit.”**

– Jawaharlal Nehru

Thank You

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